

What is a Role-Playing Game?

A role-playing game (RPG) is a co-creation game in which players assume the roles of characters in a fictional setting. Players act out these roles within a story, both through literal acting and verbal description. A Storyteller (“Game Master” in many other games) is responsible for describing the world, playing all characters that are not player characters, presenting the plot, and helping the story progress.

In a small American town, someone is killing people and taking their blood, which is always a problem for vampires. If it is a human being, it might draw attention to the true predators of the night.

If it is Kindred¹, the Masquerade² is in jeopardy. If it is something else...

In this quickstart scenario of Vampire: the Masquerade fifth edition, you and a couple of friends will portray inhuman vampires doing their best to stay unliving in a world filled with peril. In this particular instance, they have been tasked to find a killer before the increased police and civilian scrutiny causes trouble for the vampires in the region.

What you will need:

- A copy of this document, preferably printed so you can refer to it during play and hand out physical copies of the characters and handouts.
- Five people, one of whom is acting as Storyteller (and who should be the only one reading all of this document).
- Pens and paper for taking notes.
- Several ten-sided dice in two colors.

NOTE: Vampire: the Masquerade is a mature game, dealing with serious and sometimes disturbing themes. Make sure that all participants are comfortable with this before playing the game. “The Monster(s)” contains explicit violence and murder, the taking of blood without consent, violations of personal integrity and references to sexual predation. Always remember that you are not your character, and that it is assumed that you are comfortable with exploring morality from a perspective that isn’t your own. Also note that this isn’t your typical “succeed or fail” RPG scenario - there are few happy endings.

The Storyteller should start by reading through the scenario at least once, so that he or she is familiar with the general outline. Present the characters to the players and distribute them as you as a group see fit. Give the players some time to read through the characters and ask any questions before you read the “Welcome to the World of Darkness” text below, which also starts off the scenario.

The rules of Vampire: the Masquerade that are relevant for this scenario are interspersed throughout, as well as in the character descriptions. Should the players go significantly “off book”, feel free to use rules presented later in the document, or you as the Storyteller will have to improvise.

¹ A term for vampires as a whole, or a single vampire

² the habit (or Tradition) of hiding the existence of vampires from humanity. Designed to protect vampires from destruction at the hands of mankind, the Masquerade was adopted after the Inquisition claimed many Kindred unlive.

Welcome to the World of Darkness

Welcome to the World of Darkness. It is a world not unlike our own, seen through a darkened lens. As the unknowing humans sleep, monstrous vampires prowl, sustaining their undead existence with human blood. Over the years, these master predators have organised themselves in a neo-feudal structure, built on bonds of blood and favor.

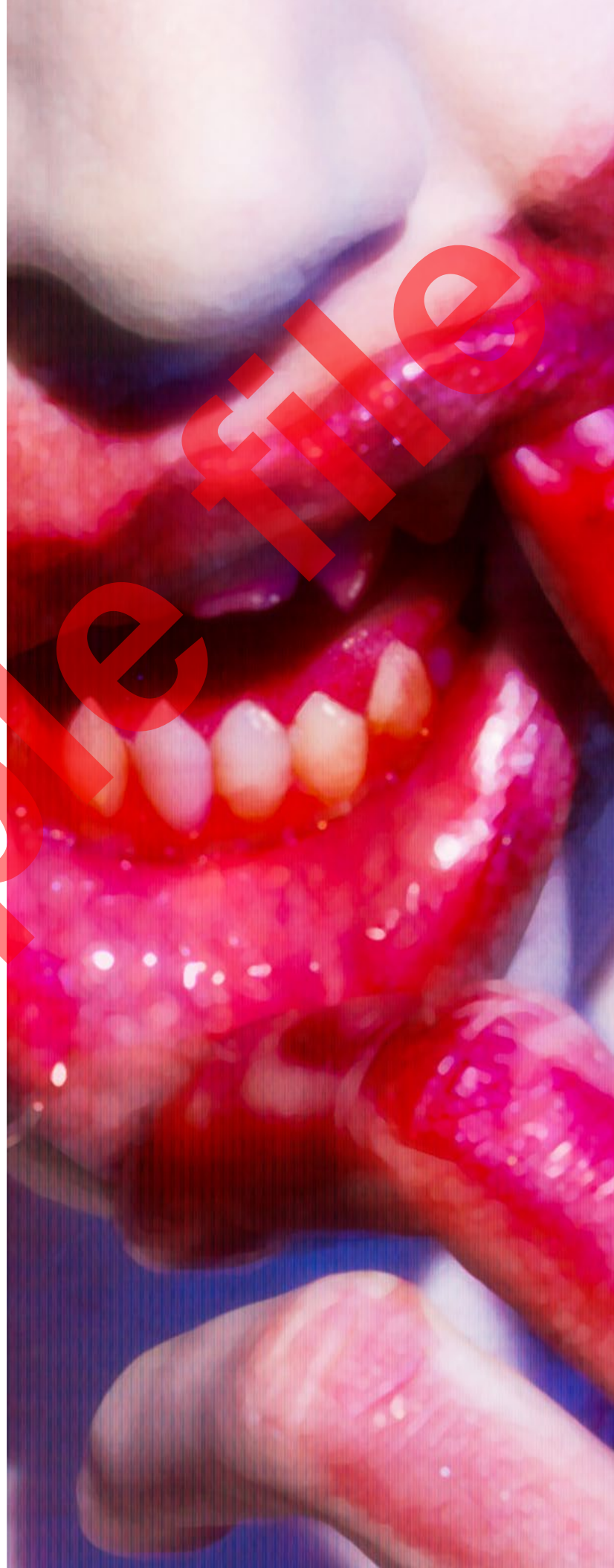
In this scenario, you will be portraying four such vampires, forming a coterie (a tight-knit group of vampires) working at the behest of their undead masters to remove threats to the Masquerade.

As vampires, you can sustain damage far beyond what would kill a mortal, and have access to vampiric powers to bend as well as break those that oppose you. However, daytime is no longer yours, and sunlight burns your flesh. Human food or drink rapidly comes up again. But that pales in comparison with the Hunger: the only thing that sustains you is blood, and sooner or later, you always want more. Deny that urge and be prepared to face the consequences.

In this particular instance, your characters have been sent to hunt for a killer who might inadvertently draw attention to vampirekind. Sam Stokes, your master, is responsible for keeping a lid on things in your region, and has sent you to meet with her contact in the local police force for more details.

The hunt for the monster(s) is on."

**ONLY THE STORYTELLER SHOULD READ
BEYOND THIS POINT!**



Introduction

“The Monster(s)” is an atypical murder mystery, in that the protagonists will not solve a “whodunnit?”. Instead, they will be confronted by their own natures as they unravel the mystery behind the murders. It is semi-railroaded in that several scenes propel the plot forward without much player input (victim three and four) but it also has several open scenes, where the player characters are left to their own devices.

The main difficulty from a Storyteller point of view is foreshadowing the reveal in chapter three just enough, as well as managing the shift in mood that occurs over chapter two.

THEME, MOOD, RECURRING MOTIFS

The themes of “The Monster(s)” are Monsters we are - outlining in red ink that vampires are indeed monsters, who not only perform monstrous acts on an almost daily basis, but also eventually sink deeper still; and What should we do with monsters?. The mood should be rage and righteousness in the first acts as the players chase the monster, shifting into personal horror as it is revealed to the players what their characters have done. Recurring motifs are the mirror, as well as punishment for wicked deeds.

Setting the Scenario

The default setting for this scenario is a small American town, the particulars of which has been left purposefully vague, so as to allow placing it wherever you like.

The same goes for the various places and people encountered during the scenario: their descriptions are concise, and it is up to you as the Storyteller to add details and depth. Is Marcus Lector a traditional suit, or more of a big game hunter? Is Martha a shrunken old figure, or a perfectly ordinary woman? Are the locations encountered moody and atmospheric, or are you highlighting their banality? Do you give verbose and comprehensive descriptions, or do you let the players' imaginations do the job? The options are endless, and we cannot tell you which ones would give the best experience for you and your group.

Storyteller notes

Below are some additional notes for the Storyteller:

- If you didn't know already, you will quickly find out that players are inventive: they will go places neither you nor the scenario designer dreamed of. When that happens, you as a Storyteller will have to improvise. This applies particularly to inventive use of Disciplines - Juana could conceivably ask the animals anything, anywhere; Paul could use Premonition anywhere. Always give away something, but not too much.
- Where does the coterie sleep during the day? It is assumed that they live in a specially furnished mobile home, but they are of course free to make other arrangements if they wish.
- If the coterie knows what is best for them, they will do their utmost to stay off the radar of regular law enforcement. Webber's protection only goes so far, and all it takes is for the police to start looking for them to make the characters' unives very difficult. Should someone encounter a mysterious mobile home in the area and decide to investigate during the day, it is likely game over. The same goes if the characters are hauled in for questioning or held in custody, since they don't suffer daylight gladly.
- The coterie is free to bring any reasonable equipment, Sam isn't stingy. But she is also adamant that it should hold up to an inspection by law enforcement.

Dramatis Personae

Here follows a brief description of the people involved in the drama. Besides these, the player characters are likely to interact with a number of different individuals, from potential witnesses to grieving families.

DETECTIVE ROBERT WEBBER, THE POLICE CONTACT

Turned by greed and Blood a long time ago, Detective Webber nowadays works for Mme Stokes (below), simply because he thinks vampires are better suited than cops to take care of any “funny business”: his name for any case that shows traces of the supernatural.

In this case there aren't any such traces, but Webber nevertheless recognises the value of vampires staying hidden. As well as catching murderers, of course.

SAM STOKES, THE KINDRED SHERIFF

Madame Sam Stokes is the law among Kindred in these parts, and has been so for a long time. Once a fieldworker, nowadays a shotcaller behind the scenes, Sam's foremost job is protecting the Masquerade. She is the one that has sent the coterie to meet with Detective Webber, and is available to contact if the coterie runs out of ideas or needs strings pulled. (She also makes an appearance in the flashback in Chapter Three.)

HARRY LLOYD, THE OBSESSED FAN

One night three decades ago, a heavily intoxicated Harry Lloyd did something that has come to plague him his entire life. He had long been obsessed with sci-fi movie mega starlet Eliza Burton, a young actress of considerable fan acclaim. A toxic fan, he took his fixation too far, frequently visiting Eliza's house without her knowledge and tracing her every movement. This fateful night, after drinking a little too much, Harry broke into Eliza's home, and when she told him to leave, he lashed out. He murdered her. Or that's what the papers and the judge said. Harry maintained his innocence — of the murder, at least — and still does to this day.

He was released from prison a few months ago and was hopeful his crime would have been forgotten. The tabloids ensured this would not be the case, clickbait articles and thinkpiece vlogs creating an Eliza Burton renaissance while portraying Lloyd as a wretched obsessive fan.

He now lives a miserable existence in his house, ostracized by the community, from which he is often the subject of harassment and vandalism. He would have moved long ago if he had the means.

The coterie might encounter Harry already in chapter one, but he otherwise shows up in chapter two.

MARCUS LECTOR, THE CLOT COLLECTOR

Marcus Lector is a vampire of means, and spends his time collecting victims with rare and delicate blood that sometimes even yields supernatural effects. He especially savors the blood of serial killers and other remorseless ne'er-do-wells, and is thus on a similar mission as the coterie.

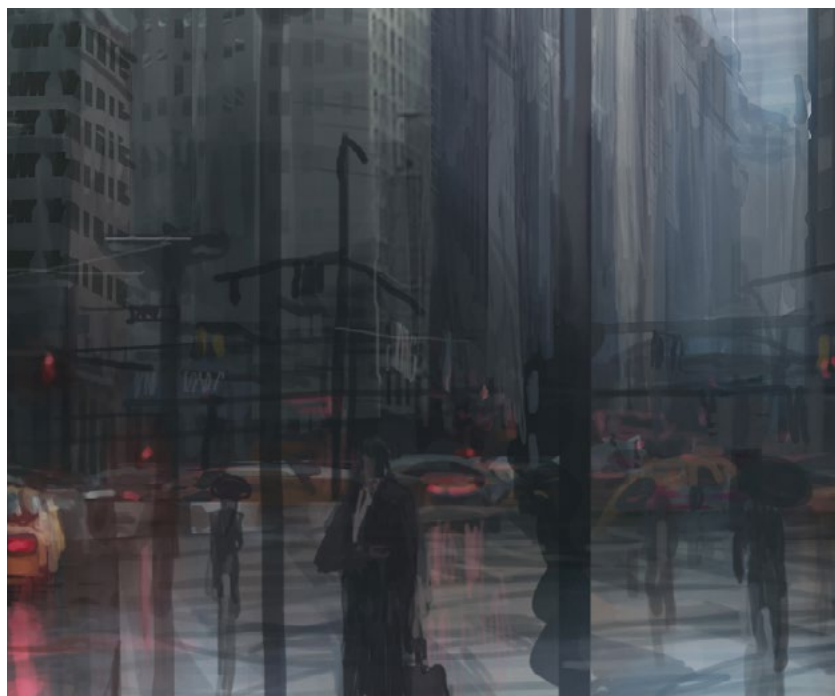
Including Marcus in the scenario is optional, serving as foil and/or opportunity, depending on the coterie's actions.

THE MONSTER

Ever since that fateful night thirty years ago poor Martha has been trying to piece together what happened to her younger sister. They say it was a serial killer, but some things don't add up. There are details missing, things subdued. Piece by piece, she has reconstructed that night at the hotel and what followed, and a whole world of darkness and pain has been revealed to her. This has caused her mind to irrevocably snap, and out of pain and vengeance she is now looking to recreate the events of thirty years ago in her own, twisted way, before her health gives out.

THE COTERIE

See the appendix for descriptions of the player characters. As with the other descriptions in the book, there is little in the way of physical description here, leaving it to the players to imagine what their characters are like. Some parts of the character sheet relate to systems not in this quickstart - ignore those for now.



Chapter 1 – Hook and introduction

“Nobody owns life, but anyone who can pick up a frying pan owns death.”
– William S. Burroughs

Chapter one is the introduction of the scenario, and will give the players plenty of leeway when it comes to actions. Hopefully they will have seen a cop show or two, so as not to be completely lost at how to investigate a murder.

Rules in this chapter:

The rules you will be using in this chapter are *basic rolls*, *willpower* and *hunger*.

Basic rolls

Basic rolls are simple - whenever a character wants to accomplish something that is difficult and the outcome is uncertain, add one character attribute (Strength, Composure, etc) to one character skill³ (Drive, Larceny, etc.), roll that many dice and count all that come up 6 or more: this is the number of successes. If the number of successes equals or exceeds the Difficulty of the task (set by the Storyteller) the character succeeds.

³ Sometimes e.g. a Discipline rating is substituted for a skill, and on some occasions two attributes are rolled

Example: Aileen wishes to distract the attendant so that the rest of the coterie can sneak into the morgue. Aileen's player rolls six dice (three dice for Aileen's Manipulation of 3, and three more for her Subterfuge of 3). The dice come up '6, 3, 5, 7, 7, 8' giving Aileen a total of four successes. Given that the Storyteller earlier set the Difficulty at 3 (a common Difficulty for challenging situations), Aileen succeeds and the attendant is properly distracted.

Criticals

Whenever you make a roll and get two or more tens ('o' on many ten-sided dice), you have scored a critical, and get two extra successes!

Willpower

Players who are unsatisfied with their rolls may spend a point of their character's Willpower - a measure of mental fortitude - to re-roll up to three non-hunger dice. Note that this may negate messy criticals and bestial failures (see below). To spend a point of Willpower, simply check one Willpower box. There is no way to regain willpower in this quickstart; what you get you need to make last until the end of the scenario.

Hunger

Hunger is the eternal curse of all vampires, driving them to hunt for blood to satisfy their bestial urges. As the hunger of a vampire increases, these urges will eventually drive it to inhuman actions. Keep track of each player charac-

ter's hunger level with off-color ten sided dice (one dice per level of hunger). It ranges from zero (satisfied) to five (ravenous). All players begin with a hunger level of one. Whenever you make a roll, substitute as many dice for hunger dice as your level of hunger.

Example: Charles has a hunger level of three, and his player has therefore placed three off-colour dice on the character sheet. When it is time to roll for a task with five dice, Charles' player substitutes three of those dice for Charles' hunger dice.

Messy criticals

Whenever you score a critical and at least one '10' ('o') comes from a hunger dice, the character's vampiric nature (also known as "The Beast") makes itself known. You get two extra successes, but perform the action as a vampire would: killing someone you were trying to subdue, flashing fangs at someone you were trying to intimidate, feeding from someone you met when canvassing, etc.

Example: when perusing the archives to find out if there have been any similar murders in the past, Paul's player rolls two tens, one of which is on a hunger die. Engrossing himself in the archives, Paul uncovers plenty of information, but when the archivist checks up on him, Paul's annoyance at being interrupted results in him breaking the archivist's arm.

If you fail to come up with something appropriate the roll just fails instead, as the Beast clouds the vampire's actions.

Bestial failure

If you fail your roll and at least one hunger die shows a '1', the Hunger interferes with your action and the Beast manifests. You cause some kind of problem for you (and probably the coterie), just like with a messy critical, while also failing spectacularly.

If you fail to come up with something appropriate, stress increases your Hunger by one instead.

Rouse checks and using the Blood

Hunger increases whenever a player fails a Rouse check, and decreases when the vampire feeds. Rouse checks are made whenever the vampire uses its Blood, and every evening when it rises from sleep. To make a Rouse check, simply roll one die, and if isn't a success, the vampire's Hunger increases by one.

Vampires can use the Blood to get an extra die on any roll, and to power their inhuman abilities, called Disciplines (each player character's Disciplines are described on their character sheet).

Example: Paul wants a little extra on a roll to escape some hunters, and uses the Blood to get an extra die. After the roll, regardless of success or failure rate, the player rolls a single die and increases Paul's hunger by one if it shows 1-5.



Example: Juana wishes to use Feral Whispers (see Juana's description in the appendix) to ask the rats in an area to warn the coterie if someone approaches. Feral Whispers has a cost of one Rouse check, so Juana's player rolls a single die and increases Juana's hunger by one if it shows 1-5.

If Hunger is already at 5, the vampire can no longer take voluntary Rouse checks.

No matter the result of the Rouse check, the desired effect (using a Discipline power, mending damage or adding the extra die) always triggers. The Rouse check only determines if Hunger increases as a result. If it does, add the Hunger dice after the effect resolves.

Feeding

Drinking blood reduces a vampire's Hunger level by a fixed amount. Draining a human of blood, thereby killing them, is the only way to reduce Hunger to 0. It takes time and care to drink blood properly. The bite of a vampire is euphoric to the victim,

due to vampire fangs having a supernatural intoxicating effect as they pierce the blood vessel. If the vampire takes the time to hit a vein or artery correctly and licks the wound closed afterward, the victim may only remember the encounter as a hazy drug trip, an interlude of weird sex, or a delirious fog of drunken intimacy.

As a general rule, attempting while feeding to preserve the victim's life, health, and ignorance (all of which of course also preserve the Masquerade) takes longer than simply ripping open an artery and slurping down the red stuff. On the other hand, a victim who fights back slows things down and endangers the Masquerade. A vampire can drain and kill a helpless or otherwise unresisting human in roughly five turns.

For the purposes of this quickstart, taking a non-lethal sip from a human reduces Hunger by one or two, completely draining a human reduces it by five, including the last Hunger dice. Draining several animals may also reduce Hunger by one.

Scene One: Meeting the Contact

This scene throws the characters straight in, and serves as an introduction to the scenario. The players should leave it with a basic outline of what has happened and some idea of what to do next.

Begin the scene by asking the players where they want to set up the meeting with their contact, and set the scene there. Depending on your players this could be a parking lot, a local dive, a deserted stretch of road, or whatever else occurs to the players. After setting the scene, ask each player in turn for a physical description of their character.

Detective Robert Webber arrives on time, and is more nervous about meeting what he knows to be the undead than he is about the clandestine nature of the meeting. He gives the player characters an outline of the victims and what the police knows (which is not a lot since he has stalled the investigation on purpose to give the player characters time to take care of business), and is then available for questions. He also gives the coterie a number where they can reach him if they need anything.

The victims

Two victims have been found so far, and the state of the bodies leave no doubt that the murders are connected. Both bodies now reside in the local morgue, awaiting processing.

Simon Drummer, college jock

Victim number one, Simon Drummer, was found four days ago, tucked away in a storm drain. Unfortunately, recent rains have made a mess of the crime scene.

Simon was a strapping young lad in his early twenties, attending college in another state but home over a hiatus in his studies. He gives the impression of being an “all-American young man” and often poses with the football sweater of his team.

Carl Thrush, basement cooker

Victim number two, Carl Thrush, was found two days ago in a copse of trees, slayed on a rock and emptied



of blood, which is why Webber immediately contacted Sam. The site has since been cleared but little else of note was found.

Carl was a man in his mid-thirties, who still lived in his parents' basement and had no registered place of work. Despite the popular images of such individuals he was quite a looker. A roll of Intelligence + Finance (Difficulty 3) reveals that he was living larger than he should be able to afford, even if supported financially by his parents.

Proceed to scene two as soon as the coterie has asked their questions and are prepared to move on with their investigation.

Scene Two: Nightly Investigations

This is an open-ended scene where the player characters are free to investigate the murders as they see fit, and should be fertile ground for skill tests. Proceed to the next scene when the players have run out of ideas and/or when play loses steam.

Give the player characters a moment to discuss their approach and decide who will do what. It's up to them if they wish to proceed as a group or split up to cover more ground. If the latter, balance the scenes so that each team has roughly the same amount of time in the spotlight. Ask each player in turn what they want their character to do during the first night. Below are some examples of leads they might want to pursue, but be prepared to improvise as well if the players come up with something unexpected.

The morgue

The bodies of the victims are still in the county morgue, awaiting processing. At night, a single attendant is there, burning the midnight oil. The characters

can gain access by breaking in with a roll of Wits + Larceny (Difficulty 3), bribing the attendant with a roll of Manipulation + Persuasion (Difficulty 3), or impersonating law enforcement with Manipulation + Subterfuge (Difficulty 4). It is also possible to simply call Sam or Webber and ask them to pull strings.

If the characters gain access they can examine the bodies themselves using Intelligence + Medicine. If several characters are present, only the one with the highest dice pool rolls, and adds one die for each other character present with at least one dot in Medicine. If they subverted the attendant, the characters will be provided some basic information.

(“CSI-stuff” is certainly possible, but will take weeks)

SUCCESSSES	INFORMATION (YOU GET EVERYTHING ON AND BELOW YOUR LEVEL OF SUCCESS)
0	They're bodies. They have been subjected to significant violence. Best not look too closely.
1	Both bodies have been savaged with at least a slashing weapon of some sort.
2	Care has been taken to slash major arteries, and there is much less blood present in the bodies than there should be. In both cases there are significant head traumas from blunt objects as well.
3	The attacker seems an odd mix of competent and furious. There are no fang marks anywhere on the bodies, but given the Kindred's ability to close fang marks with saliva, this doesn't rule out a vampire assailant.
4	There is little subterfuge here: the murderer seems to have acted out of rage, and given that crimes of passion usually involve people with knowledge of one another these were probably not random victims.
5+	The victims were likely incapacitated by the blow to the head, and only later slashed. There seems to be no pre-mortem damage, which clashes somewhat with the rage theory.

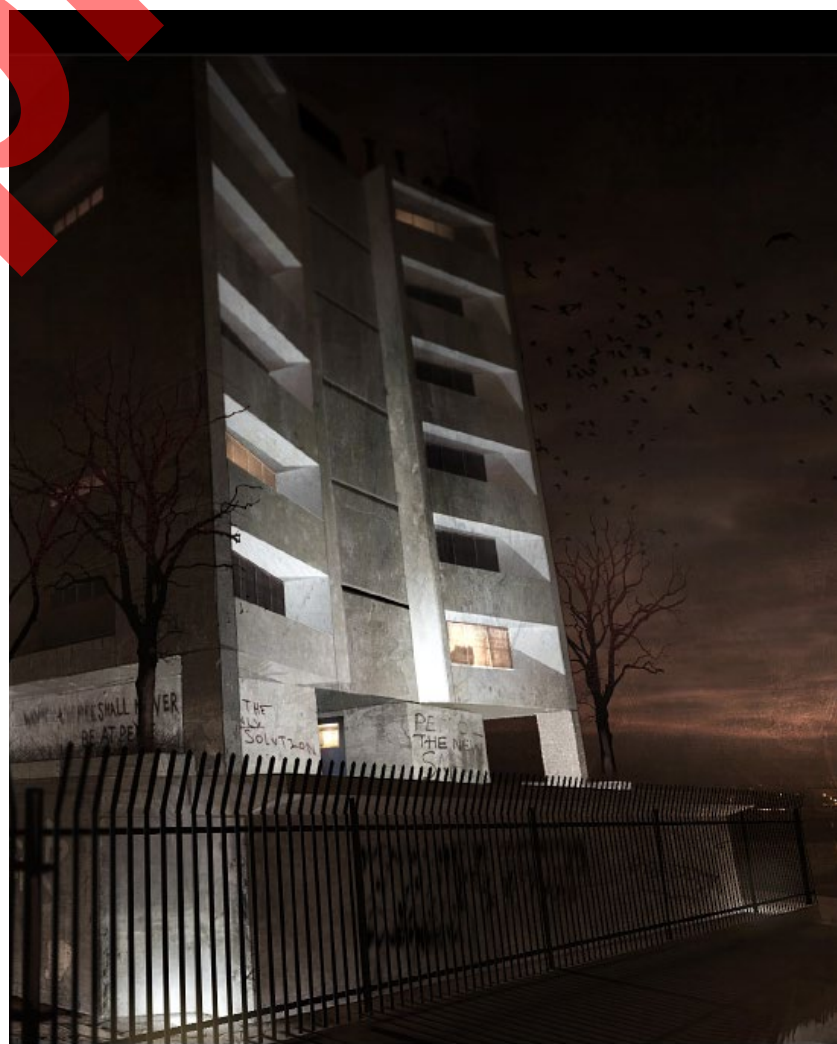
The murder scenes

Unfortunately, there is very little at the two murder scenes. Some blood from the victim can be found on the second scene if one really looks, but this says nothing the coterie doesn't already know.

NOTE: Juana can talk to the animals at the two scenes, and they confirm that someone did indeed kill someone here. There was also a lot of blood.

The police precinct

Going to see the police is unwise. The characters likely have no credible alibis, and little reason to be in the area. Drawing attention to themselves from the authorities is a bad idea (see “Dealing with law enforcement”). There is also nothing the police can tell the coterie that Detective Webber can't. Should the coterie go there against better judgement, Webber will call them shortly thereafter to berate them.



The families

Interviewing the families of the victims under whatever pretext is a straightforward task, and they are a little confused that the police haven't done so already. Unless approached early in the night, they will be asleep when the characters arrive.

Simon Drummer's family is very forthcoming, and best interviewed with a Charisma + Persuasion roll.

SUCCESSSES	INFORMATION (YOU GET EVERYTHING BELOW YOUR LEVEL OF SUCCESS AS WELL)
0	The coterie gets nothing but polite pleasantries.
1	Simon had no enemies and was well-liked by everyone.
2	All that slander about him is blatantly false, and will not be repeated.
3	Several girlfriends have claimed Simon had been "less than a perfect gentleman" with them.
4	Simon was a good kid, really, it was just that sometimes they made him so angry, you know?
5+	Simon once confessed he felt pressured to live up to expectations, and thus "could get a little rough with girls, because that's what they like, and what is demanded of him by the other guys". His parents made him apologize to every one of his former girlfriends when they discovered this.

Carl Thrush's family is less forthcoming, and wants nothing to do with the coterie, even should they claim to be police. They can be forced to talk with Charisma + Intimidation, if the coterie is okay with bullying information out of a traumatized family.

SUCCESSSES INFORMATION (YOU GET EVERYTHING ON LOWER LEVELS)

0	"Whoever you are, fuck off!"
1	Carl claimed to have plenty of enemies: people who wished him ill and often assaulted him. The parents have never seen these people.
2	Carl was a successful businessman, and paid for room and board at his parents' place.
3	Carl instructed his parents to "get rid of all his stuff if something happened" so the parents burnt it all. He'd had a lot of chemistry equipment, a computer and bundles of unsent packages.
4	Carl's business involved a lot of chemistry, strange smells, and lots of packages going out. He had all contacts on his computer.
5+	Carl was deeply paranoid, and lately complained that someone was stalking him "AFK", whatever that means.

Asking around

Canvassing the neighborhood is done with Resolve + Investigation or Streetwise, and the result varies with what the characters are asking about. Allow anyone who spends significant time asking around to roll, and "purchase" appropriate clues for the players (they don't automatically get everything on lower levels).

SUCCESSSES INFORMATION TIDBITS

0	You get nothing!
1	• Suspicious people have been sneaking about lately (dubious). • The police around here are irreparably corrupt (true, as the characters should know). • Simon's trollops like it rough, everyone knows that (not true). • Carl is a basement creep who deserved what he got (not true).